

# SESSION EIGHT: THE UNKEPT VIGIL

*The Qilvayas Symphony*

*An adventure for 4–6 characters of 7th level — the rite floor, the last champion, and the funeral that never happened*

## OVERVIEW

Beyond the Witness Hall lies the Rite Floor, and on it, still speaking his half of a covenant into the dark, Threnvos. He is present, responsive, and worn past everything except the ceremony — two thousand years of grief have taken language, memory, and self, and left only the words he was saying when it happened. He cannot answer questions. He says his part, and waits for a response that never came, and begins again.

The session's work is the Vigil: someone sits, someone watches, someone speaks the responses nobody spoke. It takes the whole night — which means the party must commit to remaining in the dark until a dawn they cannot see. The hunger that shares his grave will try to stop them, because the Vigil is the only thing that can take anything away from it. And when the Vigil is kept, the grief goes out of the room, and the room gets colder, and what remains does not grieve, does not remember, and wants nothing except more.

Designed for a five-hour core. Pacing budget: the arch and the first hearing (30 minutes); the Rite Floor and Threnvos (60 minutes); understanding what he needs (45 minutes); the Vigil, in three watches with interruptions (120 minutes); the parting and the ascent (45 minutes). Optional content adds roughly 60 minutes. Milestone: 8th level at the Vigil's completion.

## WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Threnvos was killed by his sworn brother under the Matron's own witness and buried under a wall, under a forum, under a founding myth — with no Vigil, no watching, no light, and nobody to see him home. In a culture where doctrine holds that the Matron watches the dead home and does it at night, and that the Vigil is owed to the dead as dead and not as the good, that is not merely a cruelty. It is the wound. The thing beneath Aenodira is an unkept vigil two thousand years long, and it has been waiting in the dark for someone to sit with it.

The entity has two fused components: Threnvos's grief, which is a person and can be laid to rest, and the impersonal hunger the broken covenant unleashed, which is not and cannot. Keeping the Vigil separates them. It is a real victory and it is not the victory: the grief goes quiet because it was the only part a funeral could touch, and what is left is hunger, fed for two centuries by an empire that keeps breaking its word and looking away. The party should feel this as loss — something recognizably personal leaves the world, and what remains is worse for being emptier. The nastiest implication is one they will reach on their own, probably on the walk up: the part they just gave peace to was the part that could, in principle, have been reasoned with.

This is the campaign's pivot from dungeon problem to civilization problem. What remains is fed by Norr's oath-web if he ever breaks it, by Vasq's unspoken order, by Karvel's coronation covenant sworn in the wrong direction, by every deserter at every Redwatch, and by every institution that looks away. Either the empire learns to keep its word, or the thing beneath it never stops eating — which makes the Zhuvedian Laws the actual weapon, and the Grey-Gold Rising considerably more than a set piece.

On the Matron: she may well be down here, and may always have been, keeping the vigil nobody else would. Divine magic works normally in the deep reach; clerics who pray receive. But there is never a form, never a voice, never a confirmation, and no amount of investigation resolves it — the ambiguity is permanent and deliberate. What sells it is the quality of the answer: two thousand years of doctrine about the She-Wolf who watches the dead home, and none of it prepares a devout character for the fact that what answers in this room is grieving.

## SCENE 1: THE ARCH, AND THE FIRST HEARING

*The western arch was never scoured, because nothing on it bore a name. Beyond it the stair goes down only a little further, and then the smell of cedar and resin is suddenly strong — the incense of a rite, in the moments before it begins — and under it, for the first time, you hear words. A voice. Not the breathing: a voice, speaking slowly and clearly in a language none of you know, in the cadence every one of you recognizes, because you have all sworn oaths in that cadence. It reaches the end of a phrase. It stops. It waits. The silence goes on a beat too long, and then a beat too long again, and then it begins the same phrase from the start.*

Let the party listen. They will work out the shape before they understand a word: this is someone swearing an oath and pausing for a response that does not come. A DC 15 Intelligence (History), or any character with Old Imperial or academy liturgical training, recognizes the *\*form\** — an antiphonal covenant-rite, the oldest kind, where two parties alternate lines. Nobody at the table can translate the words yet. That is correct and intentional.

## SCENE 2: THE RITE FLOOR

*The chamber is not large. After the Hall it feels almost domestic — a room built for two people to stand close together in front of witnesses far above. Everything in it is paired: twin plinths, twin basins, two low stone seats, an approach from either side converging at the center. It is still set. Two thousand*

*years and the vessels are still in place, the cloths still folded, the ceremony still laid out and waiting. And at the center, facing a place where no one stands, is what is left of the second champion.*

On Threnvos's presentation: do not make him a monster and do not make him a ghost of the tragic-noble kind. He is a shape that the eye keeps failing to finish — tall, robed in the vestments' twin, features that resolve for half a second at a time and are Drow, and old, and unbearably tired. He does not menace. He does not notice the party at first. He is mid-rite and has been for two millennia.

## WHAT HE CAN AND CANNOT DO

**He speaks only the ceremony.** Grief has worn away language, memory, and self, and left the covenant — the way severe aphasia can take speech but leave a song known since childhood. He cannot answer questions, cannot explain the founding, cannot name Zhuvendus. Do not let him become an exposition dispenser; the truth comes from Vaelindra's names, the Tarnovari ballad cycle, and Nyreeza's documents, which is where it belongs.

**He is a participant, not a recording.** He must demonstrably respond to the party specifically, or the whole scene reads as scripted. Three beats to deploy as they land: he goes silent and still if anyone speaks a sworn word aloud in this room, and waits, and then resumes when it is not the response; he turns toward whoever carries Dren's medallion and does not turn away again; and if a character who has broken an oath in play comes within ten feet, he stops mid-phrase, and something like recognition crosses whatever he has instead of a face, and it is not accusation — it is company.

**He cannot be fought, and should not be.** He has no stat block by design. Attacks pass through him with the sensation of putting one's hand into cold water. If a party insists on hostility, the room grows colder and he keeps going, and eventually the players will feel the shape of what they are doing to a man who is trying to finish a wedding.

## UNDERSTANDING WHAT HE NEEDS

The party has every piece required. They have kept a Vigil (Session One, if they did — and if they did not, this is where that omission returns). They know the doctrine: watched, lit, never left alone, owed to the dead as dead. They have just spent a session learning that witnessing lays the unquiet to rest (the Turned). And they are standing in front of a man who never got any of it. Let them assemble it. Nudges if needed, in escalating order: the ceremony pauses for a response; the second set of vestments in their pack; a devout character's training; and finally, if the table is truly stuck, a cleric who prays receives — not words, just the certainty of what is owed here, and the distinct impression that whatever answered is already doing it and has been for a very long time.

## SCENE 3: THE VIGIL

The Vigil requires the full night: light kept burning, the dead attended, never left alone, and — here — the responses spoken. Structure it as three watches, and put a real interruption in each. The hunger cannot stop them by force; it can only try to make them stop themselves.

## RUNNING THE WATCHES

**Watch One — the Cold.** The temperature drops hard enough to matter. Each character makes a DC 13

Constitution save at the watch's midpoint; failure means one level of exhaustion. Fire helps and the party will think of it. What the scene is really asking is whether they will spend resources on a corpse's comfort. (DM: the cold is not an attack. It is the room resisting being warmed. Describe it as reluctance, not malice.)

**Watch Two — the Unwitnessed.** The hunger sends the only thing it has: four Unwitnessed (five for five characters, six for six), the shapeless residue of things that happened here and were not seen. They do not want to kill the party — they want the Vigil broken, and they target light sources, the vestments, and whoever is speaking the responses. A party that fights them while maintaining the Vigil (at least one character continuously attending, light kept) wins the encounter in the way that matters. A party that abandons the Vigil to fight cleanly must begin the watch again.

**Watch Three — the Offer.** The subtlest and the best. In the small hours, the hunger stops attacking and starts talking — not aloud, and not to everyone: to one character, in the voice of the person whose promise they confessed in the Long Approach. It is not an illusion and not a charm, and it does not lie. It simply offers, with perfect sincerity, to let them go back and keep that promise instead. No save; nothing compels. The DM asks the player what their character does, and the answer is the character's. If they leave the Vigil, the others can complete it without them — and that character carries something for the rest of the campaign.

## THE RESPONSES

Speaking Threnvos's missing half is the Vigil's substance, and no character knows the words. This is intentional. The party must improvise — whatever a character says, in whatever language, in the pauses he leaves. It does not need to be correct. It needs to be a response, offered in good faith, in the right place. Let the players write the second half of the founding covenant themselves, out loud, at the table.

*Near dawn — you have no way to know it is dawn, and every one of you knows it anyway — he reaches the end of a phrase, and stops, and someone answers, and he does not begin again. For the first time in two thousand years the rite goes forward. He turns. He has no face to show you and he turns anyway, and something in the shape of him settles, the way a man sets down a weight he has carried so long he had stopped calling it a weight. He is not grateful. He is not at peace, exactly. He is finished. And then he is not there, and the vestments in your pack are suddenly, ordinarily warm, and the cold in the room that was grief is gone entirely — and the room is colder than it has ever been.*

## SCENE 4: WHAT REMAINS

Give this its full time. The Vigil is complete, a man is at rest, and every instinct the party has says they have won. Then let them notice, one detail at a time, that the thing beneath Aenodira is still here — and that it is worse.

The breathing has not stopped. It has changed: no longer slow and sleeping, but shallow and attentive, the sound of something that has just lost something and has not yet decided what that means.

Dren's medallion is colder than it has ever been — and for the first time since Redwatch, whoever carries it can feel it \*listening\*.

A character who prays receives, still. And whatever answers is no longer grieving. It is simply present, and waiting, and the difference between those two things is the entire back half of this campaign.

The party has separated a murdered man from the appetite that wore his grief as a face. What is left does not remember Threnvos, does not want justice, and cannot be reasoned with, because the part that could have been reasoned with is the part they just laid to rest. It has been fed for two hundred years by an empire that breaks its word and looks away, and it will keep eating as long as that continues. There is no monster to kill at the bottom of this hole. There is a civilization to fix.

The way out is the way they came. The Second Seal will not close behind them — the frost does not re-form. Let them notice that too.

## SCENE 5: THE ASCENT, AND WHO TO TELL

They come up into Aenodira with the vestments, the rubbing, Nyreeza's notes, an archive shelf-mark, and the knowledge of what the empire is standing on. The session's last forty-five minutes belong to the decision that shapes the campaign's second half: who learns any of this.

**Vaelindra:** She promised them the names when they came back alive. She keeps that promise — Zhuvedus, Threnvos, the Oathbreaker's fall, all of it — and she is the only person who can tell them the funeral was real and insufficient without it sounding like defeat. If they tell anyone, tell her first.

**Shen:** Gets them the archive. The dynastic shelf-mark is beyond a mercenary company and routine for the Bureau of Correspondence. She will also, correctly, identify the rubbing as the most dangerous object in the empire, and ask a question the party may not want to answer: what do you intend to do with it?

**Vell:** Can date the frieze, read the old orthography of the nine names, and will be the first person to say aloud that the Golden Tablets postdate the Hall. He will need to sit down.

**The throne:** Nyreeza's last instruction was do not follow, and the party now knows why — and also knows the Laws are the weapon. Telling Qilvayas is no longer a betrayal of her wishes; it may be the completion of them. This remains the campaign's largest gate. Handle deliberately.

**Nobody:** Also a choice. The Hall taught them exactly what it costs, and they will make it anyway if they are frightened enough, which is the most human ending this arc has.

**Milestone:** 8th level. The first arc of the campaign is closed: students, vision, Seeress, Proving, dead letters, the Seal, the Hall, and a funeral two thousand years late. The second arc is the empire itself.

## OPTIONAL CONTENT (BEYOND THE FIVE-HOUR CORE)

**The Vestments Returned (~30 minutes):** The party carries the second champion's unworn ceremonial dress. Options with weight: burn them properly with a Vigil of their own at any shrine; carry them to Tarnovar, where a Voivode who does not know why will nonetheless know exactly what she is being handed; or give them to Qilvayas, which is either the kindest or the cruelest thing anyone has ever done to that man. No wrong answer; every answer is a scene.

**What the Wolves Knew (~20 minutes):** In the days after, the wolves of Aenodira begin returning to the Old Forum district — slowly, family by family, reversing three years of quiet exodus. Nobody in the city can explain it. A party with a companion wolf notices first, and a party that pays attention learns something true and unspoken: something down there is at rest that was not before. It is the only unambiguous good news this arc produces, and it arrives without commentary.

**The Fourth Letter (~30 minutes):** Nyreeza's abandoned drafts to her son can be finished — by the party, in her hand or their own, and delivered. The scene is not about whether Qilvayas believes it. It is about whether they choose to give a grieving man eleven words his mother could not finish. If the campaign ever opens the sealed dispatch case, this is the beat it will be measured against.

## DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

Record outcomes in the Branch Ledger.

**The Vigil kept, broken, or refused:** Kept: Threnvos is at rest permanently, the hunger is exposed and alone, and the campaign proceeds as designed. Broken and resumed: the same outcome, one night later, with the party knowing they faltered. Refused entirely: Threnvos remains, the entity stays fused, and the campaign keeps a monster that can still be spoken to — a genuinely different and viable second half. Do not force the funeral.

**Watch Three — who took the offer:** A character who left the Vigil to chase a kept promise carries it forward: they know they were offered their worst regret and reached for it, in front of everyone. No mechanical penalty. Considerable narrative weight, and the entity now knows exactly what that character is worth.

**The responses, verbatim:** Whatever the players improvised as the covenant's missing half is now canon — the actual second voice of the founding rite, spoken two thousand years late by people who were not there. Write it down. If the campaign ever needs a counter-oath, a binding, or words to end things with, use theirs.

**Who they told:** The single largest branch in the campaign. Vaelindra opens the mythology; Shen opens the archive and the politics; Vell opens the scholarship and the scandal; the throne opens everything at once and cannot be closed;

nobody preserves the status quo at a cost the Hall already named. Sessions Nine onward are built from this answer.

**Did they keep the Redwatch Vigil (Session One)?** If yes, the party arrives at the solution here intuitively and the DM should reward the callback openly. If no, make the omission felt — not punitively, but the realization that they have done this wrong once before, to eight men in a ruined fort, should land somewhere in this session.

## STAT BLOCKS

### The Unwitnessed

*Medium undead (residue), chaotic evil*

**Armor Class:** 13

**Hit Points:** 45 (7d8 + 14)

**Speed:** 0 ft., fly 30 ft. (hover)

| STR       | DEX        | CON        | INT       | WIS        | CHA        |
|-----------|------------|------------|-----------|------------|------------|
| 8<br>(-1) | 16<br>(+3) | 14<br>(+2) | 6<br>(-2) | 10<br>(+0) | 12<br>(+1) |

**Damage Resistances:** cold, necrotic; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

**Damage Immunities:** poison

**Damage Vulnerabilities:** radiant

**Condition Immunities:** charmed, exhaustion, frightened, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained

**Senses:** darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

**Languages:** —

**Challenge:** 3 (700 XP)

**Residue.** The Unwitnessed are the shapeless remainder of things that happened in this place and were not seen. They have no faces because they never had witnesses — not the same condition as the Turned, and a scholar will notice the difference.

**Break the Watch.** The Unwitnessed prioritize, in order: open flames and light sources, the ceremonial vestments, and whoever is currently speaking the responses. They will pass up an easy kill to snuff a lantern. They are not trying to win a fight; they are trying to end a funeral.

**Incorporeal Movement.** Can move through creatures and objects as difficult terrain, taking 5 (1d10) force damage if it ends its turn inside an object.

### ACTIONS

**Smothering Touch.** Melee Spell Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 13 (3d6 + 3) necrotic damage. If the target is holding a light source, it must succeed on a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw or the light is extinguished.

**Quench (Recharge 6).** All nonmagical light within 20 feet gutters and dies. Magical light of 3rd level or lower is suppressed for 1 round. The dark is the point.

Threnvos has no stat block, by design. He cannot be fought, damaged, banished, turned, or compelled. If a DM ever needs a number for him, the number is the Vigil.

## LOOT AND FOUND REWARDS — SESSION EIGHT

| Find                       | Value / Effect                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The completed Vigil        | No mechanical reward. The DM should offer none and the party should not ask.                                                                                                                            |
| The vestments, warm        | After the Vigil the second champion's dress is ordinary cloth, ordinary temperature, two thousand years old and perfectly preserved. Whatever the party does with it is a scene (see Optional Content). |
| The covenant's second half | Whatever the players improvised, now canon and recorded. Arguably the most valuable object the campaign will ever produce.                                                                              |
| The Rite Floor vessels     | Pre-imperial ceremonial silver, paired, undecayed — 400 gp to a collector, and the party will not sell them, and the DM should let them not sell them.                                                  |
| The wolves' return         | Not an item. Not a reward. The only unambiguous good news in this arc (see Optional Content).                                                                                                           |

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